

precaution on every step of the stairs, preventing him running against door-frames, turning him this way and that, as if Aramis had been the giant and Porthos the dwarf. Soul set fire to and animated matter. A horse was waiting, ready saddled, in the courtyard. Porthos mounted. Then Aramis himself took the horse by the bridle, and led him over some dung spread in the yard, with the evident intention of suppressing noise. He, at the same time, held tight the horse's nose, to prevent him neighing. When arrived at the outward gate, drawing Porthos towards him, who was going off without even asking him what for: 'Now, friend Porthos, now; without drawing bridle, till you get to Paris,' whispered he in his ears; 'eat on horseback, drink on horseback, but lose not a minute.'

'That's enough; I will not stop.'

'This letter to M. Fouquet; cost what it may, he must have it to-morrow before mid-day.'

'He shall.'

'And do not forget one thing, my friend.'

'What is that?'

'That you are riding out on a hunt for your brevet of duc and peer.'

'Oh! oh!' said Porthos, with his eyes sparkling; 'I will do it in twenty-four hours, in that case.'

'Ty.'

'Then let go the bridle—and forward, Goliath!'

Aramis did let go, not the bridle, but the horse's nose. Porthos released his hand, clapped spurs to his horse, which set off at a gallop. As long as he could distinguish Porthos through the darkness, Aramis followed him with his eyes: when he was completely out of sight, he re-entered the yard. Nothing had stirred in D'Arragnan's apartment. The valet placed on watch at the door had neither seen any light, nor heard any noise. Aramis closed his door carefully, sent the lackey to bed, and quickly sought his own. D'Arragnan really suspected nothing, therefore thought he had gained everything, when he awoke in the morning, about half-past four. He ran to the window in his shirt. The window looked out upon the court. Day was dawning. The court was deserted; the fowls, even, had not left their roosts. Not a servant appeared. Every door was closed.

'Good! all is still,' said D'Arragnan to himself. 'Never mind: I am up first in the house. Let us dress; that will be so much done.' And D'Arragnan dressed himself. But, this time, he endeavoured not to give to the costume of M. Agnan that bourgeois and almost ecclesiastical rigidity he had affected before; he managed, by drawing his belt tighter, by buttoning his clothes in a different fashion, and by putting on his hat a little on one side, to restore to his person a little of that military character, the absence of which had surprised Aramis. This being done, he made free, or affected to make free with his host, and entered his chamber without ceremony. Aramis was asleep or feigned to be so. A large book lay open upon his night-desk, a wax-light was still burning in its silver sconce. This was more than enough to prove to D'Arragnan the quiescence of the prelate's night, and the good intentions of his waking. The musketeer did to the bishop precisely as the bishop had done to Porthos—he tapped him on the shoulder. Evidently Aramis pretended to sleep; for, instead of waking suddenly, he who slept so lightly required a repetition of the summons.

'Ah! ah! is that you?' said he, stretching his arms. 'What an agreeable surprise! Ma foi! Sleep had made me forget I had the happiness to possess you. What o'clock is it?'

'I do not know,' said D'Arragnan, a little embarrassed. 'Early, I believe. But, you know, that devil of a habit of waking with the day, sticks to me still.'

'Do you wish that we should go out so soon?' asked Aramis. 'It appears to me to be very early.'

'Just as you like.'

'I thought we had agreed not to get on horseback before eight.'

'Possibly; but I had so great a wish to see you, that I said to myself, the sooner the better.'

'And my seven hours' sleep?' said Aramis. 'Take care; I had reckoned upon them, and what I lose of them I must make up.'

'But it seems to me that, formerly, you were less of a sleeper than that, dear friend; your blood was alive, and you were never to be found in bed.'

'And it is exactly on account of what you tell me, that I am so fond of being there now.'

'Then you confess, that it is not for the sake of sleeping, that you have put me off till eight o'clock.'

'I have been afraid you would laugh at me, if I told you the truth.'

'Tell me, notwithstanding.'

'Well, from six to eight, I am accustomed to perform my devotions.'

'Your devotions?'

'Yes.'

'I did not believe a bishop's exercises were so severe.'

'A bishop, my friend, must sacrifice more to appearance than a simple cleric.'

'Mordieux! Aramis, that is a word which reconciles me with your greatness. To appearances! That is a musketeer's word, in good truth! Vivent les apparences, Aramis!'

'Instead of felicitating me upon it, pardon me, D'Artagnan. It is a very mundane word which I had allowed to escape me.'

'Must I leave you, then?'

'I want time to collect my thoughts, my friend, and for my usual prayers.'

'Well, I leave you to them; but on account of that poor pagan, D'Artagnan, abridge them for once, I beg; I thirst for speech with you.'

'Well, D'Artagnan, I promise you that within an hour and a half—'

'An hour and a half of devotions! Ah! my friend, be as reasonable with me as you can. Let me have the best bargain possible.'

Aramis began to laugh.

'Still agreeable, still young, still gay,' said he. 'You have come into my diocese to set me quarreling with grace.'

'Bah!'

'And you know well that I was never able to resist your seductions; you will cost me my salvation, D'Artagnan.'

D'Artagnan bit his lips.

'Well,' said he, 'I will take the sin on my own head, favour me with one simple Christian sign of the cross, favour me with one prayer, and we will part.'

'Hush!' said Aramis, 'we are already no longer alone, I hear strangers coming up.'

'Well, dismiss them.'

'Impossible! I made an appointment with them yesterday; it is the principal of the college of the Jesuits, and the superior of the Dominicans.'

'Your staff? Well, so be it.'

'This is something in haste?'

'It is more than that, it is serious, Porthos.'

'Oh, oh!'

'D'Artagnan has questioned you, has he not?'

'Questioned me?'

'Yes, at Belle-Isle?'

'Not the least in the world.'

'Are you sure of that, Porthos?'

'Parbleu!'

'It is impossible. Recollect yourself.' 'He asked me what I was doing, and I told him—studying topography. I would have made use of another word which you employed one day.'

'"Castrametation"?'

'Yes, that's it; but I never could recollect it.'

'All the better. What more did he ask you?'

'Who M. Getard was.'

'Next?'

'Who M. Jupenet was.'

'He did not happen to see our plan of fortifications, did he?'

'Yes.'

'The devil he did!'

'But don't be alarmed, I had rubbed out your writing with India-rubber. It was impossible for him to suppose you had given me any advice in those works.'

'Ay; but our friend has phenomenally keen eyes.'

'What are you afraid of?'

'I fear that everything is discovered, Porthos; the matter is, then, to prevent a great misfortune. I have given orders to my people to close all the gates and doors. D'Artagnan will not be able to get out before daybreak. Your horse is ready saddled; you will gain the first relay; by five o'clock in the morning you will have traversed fifteen leagues. Come!'

Aramis then assisted Porthos to dress, piece by piece, with as much celerity as the most skillful valet de chambre could have done. Porthos, half stupefied, let him do as he liked, and confounded himself in excuses. When he was ready, Aramis took him by the hand, and led him, making him place his foot with

'Where for?'

'For Paris.'

Porthos bounded up in his bed, and then sank back down again, fixing his great eyes in agitation upon Aramis.

'For Paris?'

'Yes.'

'A hundred leagues?' said he.

'A hundred and four,' replied the bishop.

'Oh! mon Dieu!' sighed Porthos, lying down again, like children who contend with their bonne to gain an hour or two more sleep.

'Thirty hours' riding,' said Aramis, firmly. 'You know there are good relays,' Porthos pushed out one leg, allowing a groan to escape him.

'Come, come! my friend,' insisted the prelate with a sort of impatience.

Porthos drew the other leg out of the bed. 'And is it absolutely necessary that I should go, at once?'

'Urgently necessary.'

Porthos got upon his feet, and began to shake both walls and floors with his steps of a marble statue.

'Hush! hush! for the love of Heaven, my dear Porthos!' said Aramis, 'you will wake somebody.'

'Ah! that's true,' replied Porthos, in a voice of thunder, 'I forgot that; but be satisfied, I am on guard.' And so saying, he let fall a belt loaded with his sword and pistols, and a purse, from which the crowns escaped with a vibrating and prolonged noise. This noise made the blood of Aramis boil, whilst it drew from Porthos a formidable burst of laughter. 'How droll that is!' said he, in the same voice.

'Not so loud, Porthos, not so loud.'

'True, true!' and he lowered his voice a half-note.

'I was going to say,' continued Porthos, 'that it is droll that we are never so slow as when we are in a hurry, and never make so much noise as when we wish to be silent.'

'Yes, that is true; but let us give the proverb the lie, Porthos; let us make haste, and hold our tongue.'

'You see I am doing my best,' said Porthos, putting on his haut de chausses. 'Very well.'

'What are you going to do?'

'I will go and wake Porthos, and remain in his company till you have finished the conference.'

Aramis did not stir, his brow remained unbent, he betrayed himself by no gesture or word, 'Go,' said he, as D'Artagnan advanced to the door. 'A propos, do you know where Porthos sleeps?'

'No, but I will inquire.'

'Take the corridor, and open the second door on the left.'

'Thank you! au revoir.' And D'Artagnan departed in the direction pointed out by Aramis.

Ten minutes had not passed away when he came back. He found Aramis seated between the superior of the Dominicans and the principal of the college of the Jesuits, exactly in the same situation as he had found him formerly in the auberge at Crevecoeur. This company did not at all terrify the musketeer. 'What is it?' said Aramis, quietly. 'You have apparently something to say to me, my friend.'

'It is,' replied D'Artagnan, fixing his eyes upon Aramis, 'it is that Porthos is not in his apartment.'

'Indeed,' said Aramis calmly; 'are you sure?'

'Pardieu! I came from his chamber.'

'Where can he be, then?'

'That is what I am asking you.'

'And have you not inquired?'

'Yes, I have.'

'And what answer did you get?'

'That Porthos, often walking out in a morning, without saying anything, had probably gone out.'

'What did you do, then?'

'I went to the stables,' replied D'Artagnan, carelessly.

'What to do?'

'To see if Porthos had departed on horseback.'

'And?' interrogated the bishop.

'Well, there is a horse missing, stall No. 3, Goliath.'

All this dialogue, it may be easily understood, was not exempt from a certain affectation on the part of the musketeer, and a perfect complaisance on the part of Aramis.

'Oh! I guess how it is,' said Aramis, after having considered for a moment, 'Porthos is gone out to give us a surprise.'

'A surprise?'

'Yes; the canal which goes from Yannes to the sea abounds in teal and snipes; that is Porthos's favourite sport, and he will bring us back a dozen for breakfast.'

'Do you think so?' said D'Artagnan.

'I am sure of it. Where else can he be? I would lay a wager he took a gun with him.'

'Well, that is possible,' said D'Artagnan.

'Do one thing, my friend. Get on horseback, and join him.'

'You are right,' said D'Artagnan, 'I will.'

'Shall I go with you?'

'No, thank you; Porthos is a rather remarkable man: I will inquire as I go along.'

'Will you take an arquebus?'

'Thank you.'

'Order what horse you like to be saddled.'

'The one I rode yesterday, on coming from Belle-Isle.'

'So be it: use the horse as your own.'

Aramis rang, and gave orders to have the horse M. d'Artagnan had chosen saddled.

D'Artagnan followed the servant charged with the execution of this order. When arrived at the door, the servant drew on one side to allow M. d'Artagnan to pass; and at that moment he caught the eye of his master. A knitting of the brow gave the intelligent spy to understand that all should be given to D'Artagnan he wished. D'Artagnan got into the saddle, and Aramis heard the steps of his horse on the pavement. An instant after, the servant returned.

'Well?' asked the bishop.

'Monseigneur, he has followed the course of the canal, and is going towards the sea,' said the servant.

'Very well!' said Aramis.

Chapter LXXXIII

In Which Porthos Begins To Be Sorry For Having Come With D'Artagnan



CARCEL'Y had D'Artagnan extinguished his taper, when Aramis, who had watched through his curtains the last glimmer of light in his friend's apartment, traversed the corridor on tiptoe, and went to Porthos's room. The giant who had been in bed nearly an hour and a half, lay grandly stretched out on the down bed.

He was in that happy calm of the first sleep, which, with Porthos, resisted the noise of bells or the report of cannon: his head swam in that soft oscillation which reminds us of the soothing movement of a ship. In a moment Porthos would have begun to dream. The door of the chamber opened softly under the delicate pressure of the hand of Aramis. The bishop approached the sleeper. A thick carpet deadened his steps, besides which Porthos snored in a manner to drown all noise. He laid one hand on his shoulder—'Rouse,' said he, 'wake up, my dear Porthos.' The voice of Aramis was soft and kind, but it conveyed more than a notice,—it conveyed an order. His hand was light, but it indicated danger. Porthos heard the voice and felt the hand of Aramis, even in the depth of sleep. He started up. 'Who goes there?' cried he, in his giant's voice.

'Hush! hush! It is I,' said Aramis.

'You, my friend? And what the devil do you wake me for?'

'To tell you that you must set off directly.'

'Set off?'

'Yes.'

Porthos had fallen asleep in his chair and snored like an organ. At midnight he woke up and they sent him to bed. 'Hum!' said he, 'I was near falling asleep; but that was all very interesting you were talking about.'

At one o'clock Aramis conducted D'Artagnan to the chamber destined for him, which was the best in the episcopal residence. Two servants were placed at his command. 'To-morrow, at eight o'clock,' said he, taking leave of D'Artagnan, 'we will take, if agreeable to you, a ride on horseback with Porthos.'

'At eight o'clock!' said D'Artagnan; 'so late?'

'You know that I require seven hours' sleep,' said Aramis.

'That is true.'

'Good-night, dear friend!' And he embraced the musketeer cordially.

D'Artagnan allowed him to depart; then, as soon as the door closed, 'Good!' cried he, 'at five o'clock I will be on foot.'

This determination being made, he went to bed and quietly, 'put two and two together,' as people say.

In fact, D'Artagnan, dismissing all suspicion, hastened towards the ocean, constantly hoping to see in the Landes, or on the beach, the colossal profile of Porthos. He persisted in fancying he could trace a horse's steps in every puddle. Sometimes he imagined he heard the report of a gun. This illusion lasted three hours; during two of which he went forward in search of his friend—in the last he returned to the house.

'We must have crossed,' said he, 'and I shall find them waiting for me at table.'

D'Artagnan was mistaken. He no more found Porthos at the palace than he had found him on the sea-shore. Aramis was waiting for him at the top of the stairs, looking very much concerned.

'Did my people not find you, my dear D'Artagnan?' cried he, as soon as he caught sight of the musketeer.

'No; did you send any one after me?'

'I am deeply concerned, my friend, deeply, to have induced you to make such a useless search; but, about seven o'clock, the almoner of Saint-Paterne came here. He had met Du Vallon, who was going away, and who, being unwilling to disturb anybody at the palace, had charged him to tell me that, fearing M. Gerard would play him some ill turn in his absence, he was going to take advantage of the morning tide to make a tour of Belle-Isle.'

'But tell me, Goliath has not crossed the four leagues of sea, I should think.'

'There are full six,' said Aramis.

'That makes it less probable still.'

'Therefore, my friend,' said Aramis, with one of his blandest smiles, 'Goliath is in the stable, well pleased, I will answer for it, that Porthos is no longer on his back.' In fact, the horse had been brought back from the relay by the direction of the prelate, from whom no detail escaped. D'Artagnan appeared as well satisfied with as possible with the explanation. He entered upon a part of dissimulation which agreed perfectly with the suspicions that arose more strongly in his mind. He breakfasted between the Jesuit and Aramis, having the Dominican in front of him, and smiling particularly at the Dominican, whose jolly, fat face pleased him much. The repast was long and sumptuous; excellent Spanish wine, fine Morbihan oysters, exquisite fish from the mouth of the Loire, enormous prawns from Painboeuf, and delicious game from the

moors, constituted the principal part of it. D'Artagnan ate much, and drank but little. Aramis drank nothing, unless it was water. After the repast,—

'You offered me an arquebus,' said D'Artagnan.

'I did.'

'Lend it me, then.'

'Are you going shooting?'

'Whilst waiting for Porthos, it is the best thing I can do, I think.'

'Take which you like from the trophy.'

'Will you not come with me?'

'I would with great pleasure; but, alas! my friend, sporting is forbidden to bishops.'

'Ah!' said D'Artagnan, 'I did not know that.'

'Besides,' continued Aramis, 'I shall be busy till mid-day.'

'I shall go alone, then?' said D'Artagnan.

'I am sorry to say you must; but come back to dinner.'

'Pardieu! the eating at your house is too good to make me think of not coming back.' And thereupon D'Artagnan quitted his host, bowed to the guests, and took his arquebus; but instead of shooting, went straight to the little port of Vannes. He looked in vain to observe if anybody saw him; he could discern neither thing nor person. He engaged a little fishing boat for twenty-five livres, and set off at half-past eleven, convinced that he had not been followed; and that was true, he had not been followed; only a Jesuit brother, placed in the top of the steeple of his church, had not, since the morning, by the help of an excellent glass, lost sight of one of his steps. At three quarters past eleven, Aramis was informed that D'Artagnan was sailing towards Belle-Isle. The voyage was rapid; a good north north-east wind drove him towards the isle. As he approached, his eyes were constantly fixed upon the coast. He looked to see if, upon the shore or upon the fortifications the brilliant dress and vast stature of Porthos should stand out against a slightly clouded sky; but his search was in vain. He landed without having seen anything; and learnt from the first soldier interrogated by him, that M. du Vallon had not yet returned from Vannes. Then, without losing an instant, D'Artagnan ordered his little bark to put its head towards Sarzeau. We know that the wind changes with the different hours of the day. The breeze had veered from the north north-east to the south-east; the wind, then, was almost as good for the return to Sarzeau,

'A great politician.' Aramis made a gesture of indifference.

'An all-powerful minister.'

'I only hold to the king and the pope.'

'Dame! listen then,' said D'Artagnan, in the most natural tone imaginable. 'I said that because everybody here swears by M. Fouquet. The plain is M. Fouquet's; the salt-mines I am about to buy are M. Fouquet's; the island in which Porthos studies topography is M. Fouquet's; the garrison is M. Fouquet's; the galleys are M. Fouquet's. I confess, then, that nothing would have surprised me in your enfeoffment, or rather in that of your diocese, to M. Fouquet. He is a different master from the king, that is all; but quite as powerful as Louis.'

'Thank God! I am not vassal to anybody; I belong to nobody, and am entirely my own master,' replied Aramis, who, during this conversation, followed with his eye every gesture of D'Artagnan, every glance of Porthos. But D'Artagnan was impassible and Porthos motionless; the thrusts aimed so skillfully were parried by an able adversary; not one hit the mark. Nevertheless, both began to feel the fatigue of such a contest, and the announcement of supper was well received by everybody. Supper changed the course of conversation. Besides, they felt that, upon their guard as each one had been, they could neither of them boast of having the advantage. Porthos had understood nothing of what had been meant. He had held himself motionless, because Aramis had made him a sign not to stir. Supper, for him, was nothing but supper; but that was quite enough for Porthos. The supper, then, went off very well. D'Artagnan was in high spirits. Aramis exceeded himself in kind affability. Porthos ate like old Pelops. Their talk was of war, finance, the arts, and love. Aramis played astonishment at every word of politics D'Artagnan risked. This long series of surprises increased the mistrust of D'Artagnan, as the eternal indifference of D'Artagnan provoked the suspicions of Aramis. At length D'Artagnan, designedly, uttered the name of Colbert: he had reserved that stroke for the last.

'Who is this Colbert?' asked the bishop.

'Oh! come,' said D'Artagnan to himself, 'that is too strong! We must be careful, mordioux! we must be careful.'

And he then gave Aramis all the information respecting M. Colbert he could desire. The supper, or rather, the conversation, was prolonged till one o'clock in the morning between D'Artagnan and Aramis. At ten o'clock precisely,

'M. d'Eymeris and Lyodot,' said D'Artagnan. 'Do you know these names, Aramis?'

'No,' said the prelate, disdainfully; 'they sound like the names of financiers.'

'Exactly; so they were.'

'Oh! M. Fouquet allows his friends to be hanged, then,' said Porthos.

'And why not?' said Aramis.

'Why, it seems to me—'

If these culprits were hanged, it was by order of the king. Now M. Fouquet, although superintendent of the finances, has not, I believe, the right of life and death.'

'That may be,' said Porthos; 'but in the place of M. Fouquet—'

Aramis was afraid Porthos was about to say something awkward, so interrupted him. 'Come, D'Artagnan,' said he; 'this is quite enough about other people, let us talk a little about you.'

'Of me you know all that I can tell you. On the contrary let me hear a little about you, Aramis.'

'I have told you, my friend. There is nothing of Aramis left in me.'

'Nor of the Abbé d'Herblay even?'

'No, not even of him. You see a man whom Providence has taken by the hand, whom he has conducted to a position that he could never have dared even to hope for.'

'Providence?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Yes.'

'Well, that is strange! I was told it was M. Fouquet.'

'Who told you that?' cried Aramis, without being able, with all the power of his will, to prevent the colour rising to his cheeks.

'Ma foi! why, Bazin!'

'The fool!'

'I do not say he is a man of genius, it is true; but he told me so; and after him, I repeat it to you.'

'I have never even seen M. Fouquet,' replied Aramis with a look as pure and calm as that of a virgin who has never told a lie.

'Well, but if you had seen him and known him, there is no harm in that,' replied D'Artagnan. 'M. Fouquet is a very good sort of a man.'

'Humph!'

as it had been for the voyage to Belle-Isle. In three hours D'Artagnan had touched the continent; two hours more sufficed for his ride to Vannes. In spite of the rapidity of his passage, what D'Artagnan endured of impatience and anger during that short passage, the deck alone of the vessel, upon which he stamped backwards and forwards for three hours, could testify. He made but one bound from the quay whereon he landed to the episcopal palace. He thought to terrify Aramis by the promptitude of his return; he wished to reproach him with his duplicity, and yet with reserve; but with sufficient spirit, nevertheless, to make him feel all the consequences of it, and force from him a part of his secret. He hoped, in short—thanks to that heat of expression which is to secrets what the charge with the bayonet is to redoubts—to bring the mysterious Aramis to some manifestation or other. But he found, in the vestibule of the palace, the valet de chambre, who closed his passage, while smiling upon him with a stupid air.

'Monseigneur?' cried D'Artagnan, endeavouring to put him aside with his hand. Moved for an instant the valet resumed his station.

'Monseigneur?' said he.

'Yes, to be sure; do you not know me, imbecile?'

'Yes; you are the Chevalier d'Artagnan.'

'Then let me pass.'

'It is of no use.'

'Why of no use?'

'Because His Greatness is not at home.'

'What! His Greatness is not at home? where is he, then?'

'Gone.'

'Gone?'

'Yes.'

'Whither?'

'I don't know; but perhaps he tells monsieur le chevalier.'

'And how? where? in what fashion?'

'In this letter, which he gave me for monsieur le chevalier.' And the valet de chambre drew a letter from his pocket.

'Give it me, then, you rascal,' said D'Artagnan, snatching it from his hand. 'Oh, yes,' continued he, at the first line, 'yes, I understand; and he read:—'

'Dear Friend,—An affair of the most urgent nature calls me to a distant parish of my diocese. I hoped to see you again before I set out; but I lose that hope in thinking that you are going, no doubt, to remain two or three days at Belle-Isle, with our dear Porthos. Amuse yourself as well as you can; but do not attempt to hold out against him at table. This is a counsel I might have given even to Athos, in his most brilliant and best days. Adieu, dear friend; believe that I regret greatly not having better, and for a longer time, profited by your excellent company.'

'Mordieux!' cried D'Artagnan. 'I am tricked. Ah! blockhead, brute, triple fool that I am! But those laugh best who laugh last. Oh, duped, duped like a monkey, cheated with an empty nutshell!' And with a hearty blow bestowed upon the nose of the smirking valet de chambre, he made all haste out of the episcopal palace. Furet, however good a trotter, was not equal to present circumstances. D'Artagnan therefore took the post, and chose a horse which he soon caused to demonstrate, with good spurs and a light hand, that deer are not the swiftest animals in nature.

fishermen do not see him; but he follows them with interest; he divines them; he calls them; he attracts them into the way to the port. I resemble this watcher; from time to time some news reaches me, and recalls to my remembrance all those I loved. Then I follow the friends of old days over the stormy ocean of the world, I, a poor watcher, to whom God has kindly given the shelter of a sentry-box.'

'Well, what did I do when I came from England?'

'Ah! there,' replied Aramis, 'you get beyond my depth. I know nothing of you since your return. D'Artagnan, my eyes are dim. I regretted you did not think of me. I wept over your forgetfulness. I was wrong; I see you again, and it is a festival, a great festival, I assure you, solemnly! How is Athos?'

'Very well, thank you.'

'And our young pupil, Raoul?'

'He seems to have inherited the skill of his father, Athos, and the strength of his tutor, Porthos.'

'And on what occasion have you been able to judge of that?'

'Eh! mon Dieu! on the eve of my departure from Paris.'

'Indeed! tell me all about it!'

'Yes; there was an execution at the Grève, and in consequence of that execution, a riot. We happened, by accident, to be in the riot; and in this riot we were obliged to have recourse to our swords. And he did wonders.'

'Bah! what did he do?'

'Why, in the first place, he threw a man out of the window, as he would have flung a sack full of flock.'

'Come, that's pretty well,' said Porthos.

'Then he drew, and cut and thrust away, as we fellows used to do in the good old times.'

'And what was the cause of this riot?' said Porthos.

D'Artagnan remarked upon the face of Aramis a complete indifference to this question of Porthos. 'Why,' said he, fixing his eyes upon Aramis, 'on account of the two farmers of the revenue, friends of M. Fouquet, whom the king forced to disgorge their plunder, and then hanged them.'

A scarcely perceptible contraction of the prelate's brow showed that he had heard D'Artagnan's reply. 'Oh, oh!' said Porthos; 'and what were the names of these friends of M. Fouquet?'

'I' said the musketeer, with a burst of laughter that did not conceal his embarrassment: for, from those words, Aramis was not unlikely to be acquainted with his last relations with the king. 'I! Oh, tell me all about that, pray, Aramis?'

'Yes, it was related to me, a poor bishop, lost in the middle of the Landes, that the king had taken you as the confidant of his amours.'

'With whom?'

'With Mademoiselle de Mancini.'

D'Artagnan breathed freely again. 'Ah! I don't say no to that,' replied he.

'It appears that the king took you one morning, over the bridge of Blois to talk with his lady-love.'

'That's true,' said D'Artagnan. 'And you know that, do you? Well, then, you must know that the same day I gave in my resignation!'

'What, sincerely?'

'Nothing more so.'

'It was after that, then, that you went to the Comte de la Fère's?'

'Yes.'

'Afterwards to me?'

'Yes.'

'And then Porthos?'

'Yes.'

'Was it in order to pay us a simple visit?'

'No, I did no know you were engaged, and I wished to take you with me into England.'

'Yes, I understand; and then you executed alone, wonderful man as you are, what you wanted to propose to us all four. I suspected you had something to do with that famous restoration, when I learned that you had been seen at King Charles's receptions, and that he appeared to treat you like a friend, or rather like a person to whom he was under an obligation.'

'But how the devil did you learn all that?' asked D'Artagnan, who began to fear that the investigation of Aramis had extended further than he wished.

'Dear D'Artagnan,' said the prelate, 'my friendship resembles, in a degree, the solicitude of that night watch whom we have in the little tower of the mole, at the extremity of the quay. That brave man, every night, lights a lantern to direct the barks that come from sea. He is concealed in his sentry-box, and the

Chapter LXXIV

D'Artagnan Makes All Speed, Porthos Snores, and Aramis Counsels



FROM thirty to thirty-five hours after the events we have just related, as M. Fouquet, according to his custom, having interdicted his door, was working in the cabinet of his house at Saint-Mande, with which we are already acquainted, a carriage, drawn by four horses steaming with sweat, entered the court at full gallop. This carriage was, probably, expected; for three or four lackeys hastened to the door, which they opened. Whilst M. Fouquet rose from his bureau and ran to the window, a man got painfully out of the carriage, descending with difficulty the three steps of the door, leaning upon the shoulders of the lackeys. He had scarcely uttered his name, when the valet upon whom he was not leaning, sprang up to the perron, and disappeared in the vestibule. This man went to inform his master; but he had no occasion to knock at the door: Fouquet was standing on the threshold.

'Monseigneur, the Bishop of Vannes,' said he.

'Very well!' replied his master.

Then, leaning over the banister of the staircase, of which Aramis was beginning to ascend the first steps,—

'Ah, dear friend!' said he, 'you, so soon!'

'Yes; I, myself, monsieur! but bruised, battered, as you see.'

'Oh! my poor friend,' said Fouquet, presenting him his arm, on which Aramis leant, whilst the servants drew back respectfully.

'Bah!' replied Aramis, 'it is nothing, since I am here; the principal thing was that I should get here, and here I am.'

'Speak quickly,' said Fouquet, closing the door of the cabinet behind Aramis and himself.

'Are we alone?'

'Yes, perfectly.'

'No one observes us?—no one can hear us?'

'Be satisfied; nobody.'

'Is M. du Vallon arrived?'

'Yes.'

'And you have received my letter?'

'Yes. The affair is serious, apparently, since it necessitates your attendance in Paris, at a moment when your presence was so urgent elsewhere.'

'You are right, it could not be more serious.'

'Thank you! thank you! What is it about? But, for God's sake! before anything else, take time to breathe, dear friend. You are so pale, you frighten me.'

'I am really in great pain. But, for Heaven's sake, think nothing about me. Did M. du Vallon tell you nothing, when he delivered the letter to you?'

'No; I heard a great noise; I went to the window; I saw at the foot of the perron a sort of horseman of marble; I went down, he held the letter out to me, and his horse fell down dead.'

'But he?'

'He fell with the horse; he was lifted, and carried to an apartment. Having read the letter, I went up to him, in hopes of obtaining more ample information; but he was asleep, and, after such a fashion, that it was impossible to wake him. I took pity on him; I gave orders that his boots should be cut from off his legs, and that he should be left quite undisturbed.'

'So far well; now, this is the question in hand, monseigneur. You have seen M. d'Arragnan in Paris, have you not?'

'Certes, and think him a man of intelligence, and even a man of heart; although he did bring about the death of our dear friends, Lyodot and D'Eymenis.'

'At all events,' said the bishop, 'you have assumed a singular traveling costume, old friend.'

'Frightful! I know it is. You may understand why I would not travel as a cavalier or a noble; since I became rich, I am miserly.'

'And you say, then, you came to Belle-Isle?' said Aramis, without transition.

'Yes,' replied D'Arragnan; 'I knew I should find you and Porthos there.'

'Find me!' cried Aramis. 'Me! for the last year past I have not once crossed the sea.'

'Oh,' said D'Arragnan, 'I should never have supposed you such a house-keeper.'

'Ah, dear friend, I must tell you that I am no longer the Aramis of former times. Riding on horseback is unpleasant to me; the sea fatigues me. I am a poor, ailing priest, always complaining, always grumbling, and inclined to the austeries which appear to accord with old age,—preliminary parleyings with death. I linger, my dear D'Arragnan, I linger.'

'Well, that is all the better, my friend, for we shall probably be neighbors soon.'

'Bah!' said Aramis with a degree of surprise he did not even seek to dissemble.

'You my neighbour!'

'Mordiou! yes.'

'How so?'

'I am about to purchase some very profitable salt-mines, which are situated between Piriac and Le Croisic. Imagine, my dear friend, a clear profit of twelve per cent. Never any deficiency, never any idle expenses; the ocean, faithful and regular, brings every twelve hours its contingency to my coffers. I am the first Parisian who has dreamt of such a speculation. Do not say anything about it, I beg of you, and in a short time we will communicate on the matter. I am to have three leagues of country for thirty thousand livres.'

Aramis darted a look at Porthos, as if to ask if all this were true, if some snare were not concealed beneath this outward indifference. But soon, as if ashamed of having consulted this poor auxiliary, he collected all his forces for a fresh assault and new defense. 'I heard that you had had some difference with the court, but that you had come out of it as you know how to get through everything, D'Arragnan, with the honours of war.'